Book of Praise User Guide

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1. Introduction

Book of Praise is an application for displaying psalms and hymns as projected slides during a worship service. It shows sheet music one verse at a time, framed in a 16:9 slide format suitable for a projector or large screen.

The music is generated from LilyPond source files, and you can edit the notes and lyrics directly in the app.

2. Installation

2.1. Windows

The easiest option is the installer:

1. Download `BookOfPraise-Setup.exe` from the releases page.

2. Run it and follow the prompts.
3. Launch **Book of Praise** from the Start menu.

Alternatively, the portable zip is available:

1. Download the latest `bop-windows.zip` from the releases page.
2. Extract the zip to a folder of your choice.
3. Run `bop.exe` from the extracted folder.

Either way, everything needed to run the application is included.

2.2. Linux

1. Download the latest `bop-linux.zip` from the releases page.
2. Extract the zip.
3. Make sure GTK4 is installed on your system.
4. Run the `bop` program from the extracted folder.

3. Starting the Application

Double-click `bop.exe` (Windows) or run `./bop` (Linux) to start.

You can also start it from the command line with options to pre-load specific songs:

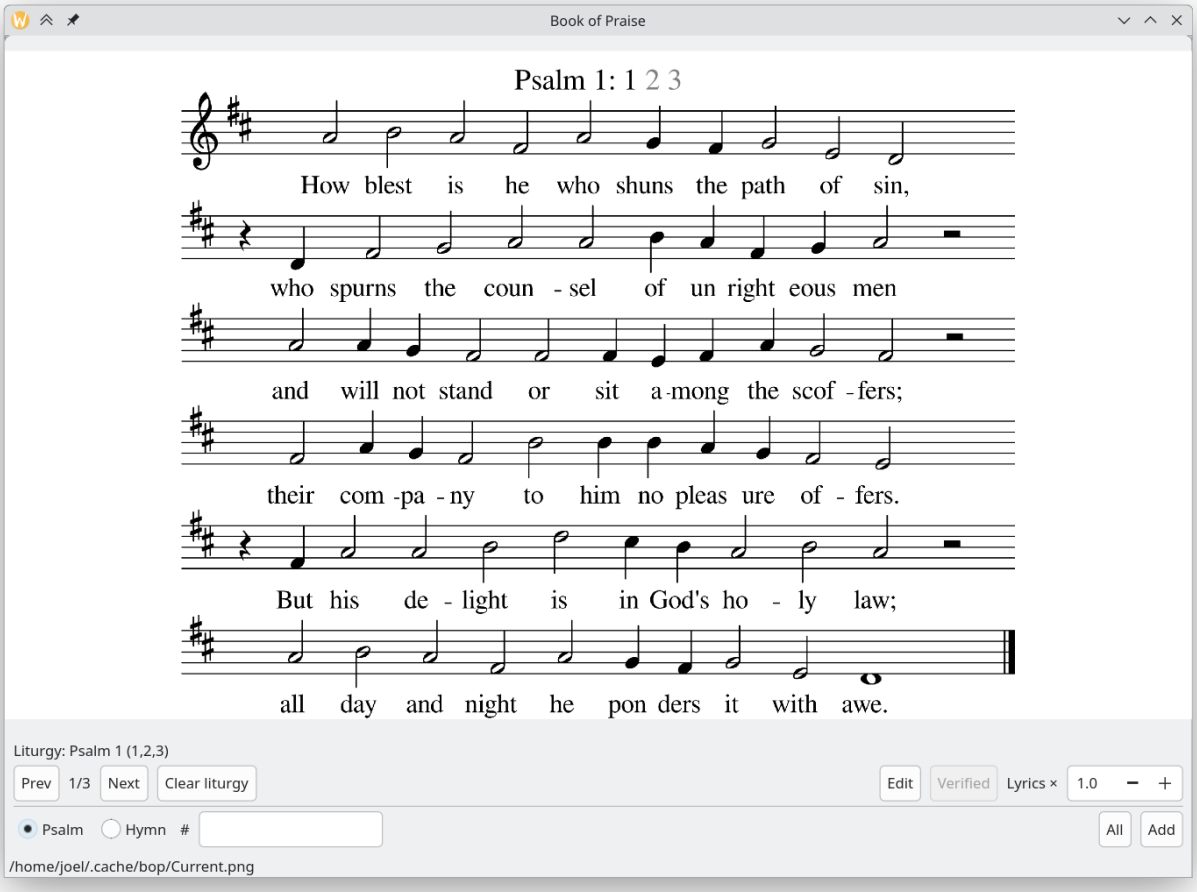
Option	What it does
`--psalm 42`	Opens with Psalm 42 loaded. Can be used more than once for multiple psalms.
`--hymn 1`	Opens with Hymn 1 loaded. Can be used more than once for multiple hymns.
`--no-update`	Skip the automatic update check on startup. (Use `--update` to force a check.)

Example: start with Psalm 42 and Hymn 1

```
bop --psalm 42 --hymn 1
```

If you don't specify any songs, the application opens with Psalm 1.

4. Main Window Overview



Slide display (centre)

The main area showing the current verse as sheet music. The title bar at the top of the slide shows the song name and verse numbers. The current verse number is shown in black; the other verses in grey.

Liturgy summary (bottom left)

Shows the list of songs you have added for the service (e.g., "Liturgy: Psalm 42 (1,2,3) | Hymn 1 (1,2)").

Navigation and toolbar (bottom centre)

Prev/**Next** buttons with a slide counter (e.g., "3/12"), **Clear liturgy** to remove all songs, **Edit** to open the music editor, **Verify** to mark a verse as checked, and a **Lyrics** × control to adjust the lyric font-size magnification.

Song input (bottom right)

Choose **Psalm** or **Hymn**, type a number, tick the verses you want, then click **Add**. Click **All** to select every verse and add it straight away.

5. Navigation

Use the **Prev** and **Next** buttons (bottom centre) to move between slides. The counter between them shows which slide you are on (e.g., "3/12").

You can also use the keyboard:

Key	Action
Left arrow	Previous slide
Right arrow	Next slide
Ctrl+S	Save and re-render (when the editor is open)

6. Building a Liturgy

The liturgy is the list of songs and verses for a service. It is shown in the summary bar (bottom left).

6.1. Adding a Song

1. Choose **Psalm** or **Hymn** and type the song number (bottom right).
2. The available verses appear as tick boxes.
3. Tick the verses you want.
4. Click **Add**.

6.2. Adding All Verses

Click **All** (bottom right) to tick every verse and add the song in one step.

6.3. Clearing the Liturgy

Click **Clear liturgy** (bottom centre) to remove all songs and start over.

7. Collaborative Proofreading

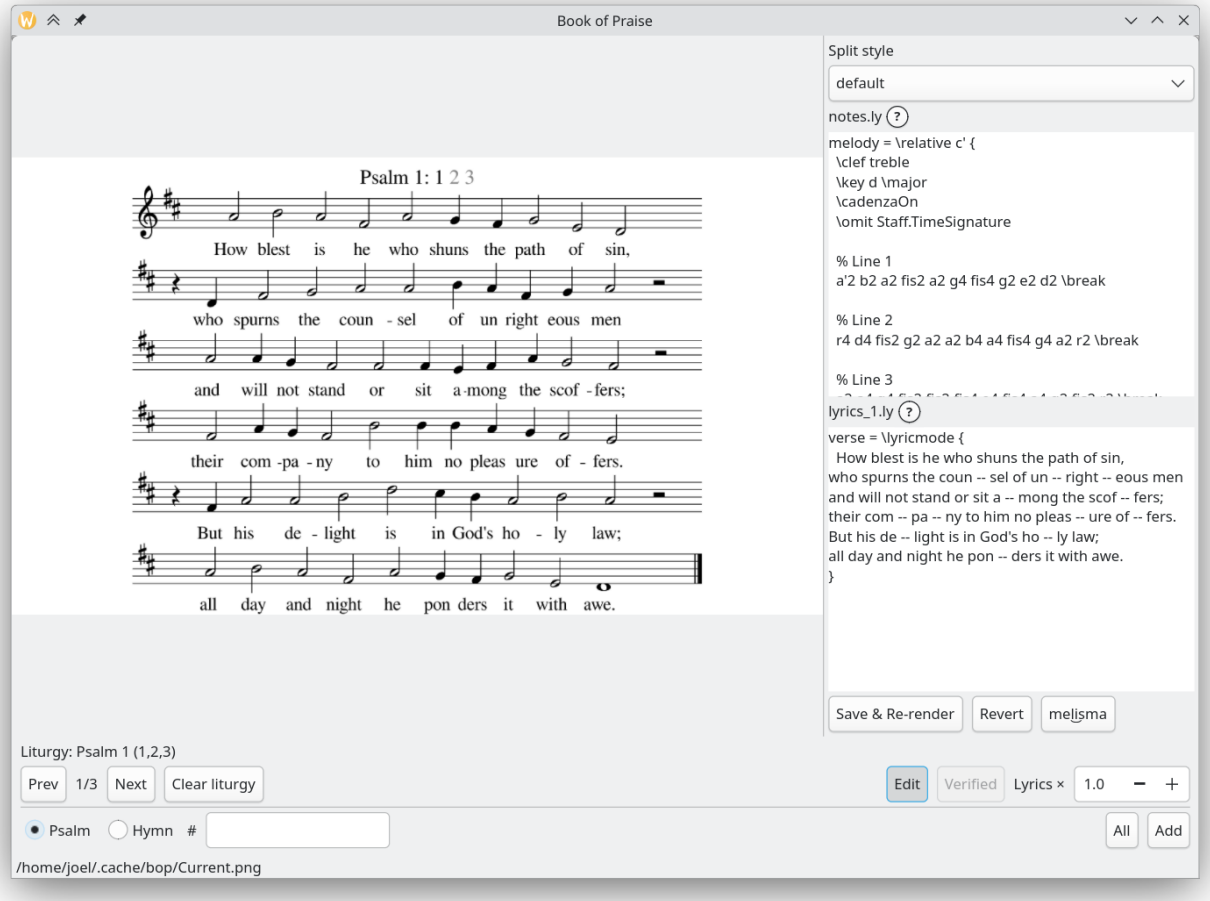
The music was converted from scanned sheet music and may contain errors. The application includes a built-in workflow for multiple people to proofread and correct the songs together:

1. **Edit** — When you spot a mistake in the notes or lyrics, open the editor and fix it right away.
2. **Submit** — When you close the application after making changes, it offers to submit your corrections to the maintainer for review.
3. **Update** — The maintainer reviews and accepts the corrections into a new release. The next time anyone starts the application, it downloads the updated songs automatically.
4. **Verify** — After checking that the music for a song is correct, mark it as verified so others know it has been proofread.

This cycle means that every congregation using the application benefits from corrections made anywhere. The sections below explain each step in detail.

8. Editing Music and Lyrics

You can correct the music notation and lyrics directly in the app. Click **Edit** (bottom centre) to open the editor panel alongside the slide.



The editor panel is laid out top-to-bottom on the right.

Split style (top)

Controls how the music is split across slides. Options:

- **default** — automatically decides based on the number of lines.
- **single slide** — forces everything onto one slide.
- **multi slide** — forces the music across multiple slides.
- **combine lines** — pairs lines together to fit more on each slide.

Notes editor

The musical notation (notes, time signature, key) shared by all verses of the song. The label shows the source file name (`notes.ly`). Click the **(?)** button next to the label for syntax help.

Lyrics editor

The words for the current verse. The label above (e.g., `lyrics_2.ly`) shows which verse you are editing. Click the **(?)** button next to the label for syntax help.

Save & Re-render (bottom)

Saves your changes and regenerates the slide. You can also press **Ctrl+S**.

Revert

Discards your unsaved edits to the notes and lyrics for the current song and reloads the saved files.

mel□isma

Inserts a combining double-breve-below character (U+035C) at the cursor in the lyrics editor. Use it to mark a slur — two notes sung on a single syllable.

Slide preview (left)

Shows the result after rendering. A spinner appears while the slide is being generated. If something goes wrong, an error message appears here.

8.1. Sending Your Edits

When you close the application after making changes, you will be asked whether to submit your corrections to the maintainer for review. If you choose **Yes**, the changes are uploaded automatically. No further action is needed on your part — the maintainer will review the corrections and include them in a future update.

9. Verifying Songs

Click **Verify** (bottom centre) to mark the current song's music as checked and correct. Verification is per song (not per verse): once you verify any verse of a song, the whole song is marked. The button changes to **Verified** once the mark has been recorded, and the status is saved in the song's `song.yaml` file.

This helps keep track of which songs have been proofread.

10. OBS Integration

Each time a slide is displayed, the application saves it as `Current.png` in the cache directory. The file path is shown at the bottom of the main window. This allows streaming tools such as OBS to use the file as an image source that updates in real time.

The file is written atomically (via a temporary file and rename), so OBS will never read a partially written image.

11. LilyPond Download

The application requires LilyPond to render music notation. It looks for LilyPond in three places:

1. Bundled next to the application executable.
2. Cached in `~/.cache/bop/lilypond-bin/` (Linux) or the local app-data cache (Windows).

3. On the system PATH.

If LilyPond is not found, a dialog offers to download and install it automatically into the cache directory. No manual installation is needed.

12. Hymn Usage Tracking

Some hymns are used under licence and their usage must be reported. The application automatically tracks when these hymns are added to a liturgy, recording one entry per hymn per day to a usage log file.

The log is stored at:

- Linux: `~/.local/share/bop/HymnUsage.txt`
- Windows: `%APPDATA%\bop\HymnUsage.txt`

On the first launch of a new year, if the log contains entries from the previous year, the application shows a dialog offering to email the report. Enter the recipient's email address and click **Send**. The report is sent as an attachment. The application remembers that the report has been sent and will not prompt again until the following year.

13. Automatic Updates

The application checks for song-data updates when it starts. Updates contain corrections to the songs themselves (the `lilypond/` and `lyrics/` folders), not a new application binary — to upgrade the application, download a fresh release.

If a new version is available:

1. A dialog asks whether to download and install the update.
2. If you choose **Yes**, the new song files are downloaded into your platform data directory (see the `lilypond/` paths under *No songs appear* in Troubleshooting) and the song list refreshes immediately.

Pass `--no-update` on the command line to skip the check.

14. Troubleshooting

Blank slide with no error

The music file for that verse may be missing. Make sure the song folder contains the source files for that verse.

Error message on the slide

The music source could not be processed. Click **Edit** to review and correct the files, then click **Save & Re-render**.

Application does not start

On Windows, if you used the portable zip, make sure all files from the zip are in the same folder as `bop.exe`. If you used the installer, try reinstalling.
On Linux, make sure GTK4 is installed.

No songs appear

The application looks for the `lilypond/` song data folder in two places: the platform data directory (`~/.local/share/bop/lilypond/` on Linux, `%APPDATA%\bop\lilypond` on Windows) — which is where automatic updates install songs — and then the same folder as the application itself. Make sure one of those locations contains the song data.